combination of nationalism, power rivalries, historical animosity, arms build-ups, and energy needs.

Will Asia see similar conflict and carnage in the 21st century as Europe saw in the 20th? This need not be so. Since the 1970s, Asia has managed to avoid great power conflict and enjoy peace and economic expansion. Different factors have been emphasised to explain the long-lasting peace between the great powers in Asia, from growing interdependence to Asian leaders giving priority to economic growth,[75] and the power balance in the region. With regard to the latter, the stability of a unipolar world based on American hegemony has been highlighted as a leading factor,[76] even though a unipolar system means that the system is "out of balance" – with one dominant state in firm grip of an unproportioned part of world power.

In recent years, the balance-of-power debate has re-emerged as a result of the distribution of power in the international system gradually tilting from the United States and Europe towards Asia. In 2011, Kenneth Pyle stated that this shift in the distribution of power and weakening of the position of the United States would lead to an emerging multipolarity in Asia, and again it was argued that this "is likely to make the region more prone to conflict."[77] However, it has recently been contended that Asia is in fact not moving towards a multipolar system with several great powers but that it is now shaped by a new bipolar world structure, with China and the United States as the two dominant global powers, and that this is a more stable system than a multipolar distribution of power.[78] Even so, Asia should not rule out the future possibility of regional stability based on a multipolar system.

If we are entering a new bipolar world structure, with China and the United States as the two superpowers, it means that China will have a relatively dominant position in Asia. Samuel Huntington wrote in 1996, based perhaps on an erroneous reading of history, that Asia, including the Indo-Pacific